

One-Pager: Game Design Principles

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Balance luck and predictability

Chance can be used to introduce new and interesting challenges to players. Author of *Death by Video Game: Danger, Pleasure, and Obsession* Simon Parkin explains, “If play is the way in which human beings rehearse life, it follows that we require our games to be filled with uncertainties” [1].

One common use of chance is in RPGs like the *Pokémon* series where attacks have a chance to become a critical hit and deal more damage. Critical hits promote players to change their strategy in response, introducing rewarding methods of engagement with the game’s systems. However, the use of luck should be balanced like other mechanics to create an experience that feels fair.

For the reasons above, I may find the use of explicit luck-based mechanics difficult to balance and potentially inappropriate for my game. However, I may balance luck and predictability through enemy actions against players, such as the decision to use one move over another. This use of luck-based mechanics remains obscure enough to appear fair to players while remaining unpredictable.

Integrate narrative into gameplay

Tying the player actions into a narrative is a great way to introduce clear objectives, reduce the explanation of core game mechanics, and reward players for completing challenges.

Baldur’s Gate 3 combines this game principle with luck-based dice rolling through ability checks. Succeeding on these checks can reward the player for playing into their character’s strengths, while failures can challenge them to think creatively to recover. In both outcomes, the player’s strategy is combined with luck and the narrative to create rewarding and engaging gameplay. However, when overused, this principle can intrude on the core gameplay loop and cause players to lose interest.

In my game, I may use environmental storytelling to implement a simple narrative to make the player’s experience more rewarding while remaining unobtrusive to core gameplay. Additionally, environmental storytelling can be technically simple to implement using the game’s art and world, making it a realistic goal given the scope of the course.

Player progression should be made apparent.

Gameplay that does not change over the game’s progression may disinterest players. One method of changing the gameplay over time is to introduce new game mechanics, but it is important that the challenges the player faces change in response.

Metroidvania games like *Hollow Knight* use a deeply interwoven environment to reward players for utilizing tools that they unlock as they progress to find shortcuts, new paths and secrets in previous areas of the game. Seeing how their character’s abilities and playstyle change over time is a core part of the reward and gameplay loop in Metroidvanias. However, game design researcher and

contributor Josh Brycer notes that, “a common trap that designers fall into is to make the beginning as tedious and frustrating as possible to easily show the evolution of the character” [2]. While it is important to highlight how a player grows over the course of the game, the player should still have enough tools at the beginning of the game to make playing an enjoyable experience.

This principle fits well with my idea for my game and previous principles, as supplying players with new tools can allow them to approach challenges based on luck differently as well as tell a narrative of a character growing over the course of the game. Overall, I plan to utilize a deeply interwoven world along with environmental storytelling and engaging luck-based mechanics to make my game as rewarding and engaging for players as possible.

Works Cited

[1] <https://nautil.us/how-designers-engineer-luck-into-video-games-236363/>

[2] <https://www.houstonpress.com/arts/the-rules-for-a-good-metroidvania-11596328/>

AI: N/A